

Feathers of Fortune

Dhanushka's poultry journey from village chickens to nutritional security



In the heart of Rambakulama, nestled within the Anuradhapura district, lies the thriving farm of Dhanushka Karunaratne, a young and ambitious entrepreneur deeply rooted in the world of poultry farming. Known as "Sekkuwa," his farm is more than just a patch of land; it is a testament to his dedication and vision. Using the education he has received, Dhanushka diligently cultivates his farm to raise village chickens, ducks, cows, and even ornamental fishes.

Initially, Dhanushka's income revolved around selling eggs, garnering him a modest sum of Rs. 10,000 per week. However, fate took a turn when Dhanushka was introduced to the Japanese Supplementary Budget (JSB) funded project, implemented by the United Nations Development Programme in Sri Lanka and the Government of Sri Lanka. Through this partnership, his weekly income skyrocketed to Rs. 20,000, a considerable leap facilitated by his collaboration with the project. Embracing the opportunity presented by the project's incubator support, he ventured into producing day-old chicks and month-old chicks, subsequently selling 400 chicks monthly at a rate of Rs.200 each.

But Dhanushka's success wasn't a solitary journey. Supported by his wife, a government nurse well-versed in the nutritional value of eggs, and an encouraging family, he found himself embraced by a community eager to support his poultry business. Leveraging the nutritional benefits of eggs, especially crucial for the health of children and elders, he embarked on a mission not just to enhance his income but also to ensure nutritional security in his area.

Today, his farm yields an impressive monthly revenue of nearly 100,000 Rs. from the sale of eggs, chicks, and even ducklings, fulfilling his family's and community's protein needs. By collaborating with the local Maize Cultivation Farmers' Society, he has also elevated the quality of production and accelerated poultry feed processing, propelling his business to new heights. The hatchery he runs has also been instrumental in assisting women in the region to boost their flock count and establish smaller-scale poultry farms.

Harnessing innovative techniques like Azolla farming and BSF larvae farming for alternative bird feeds, Dhanushka's farm stands as a beacon of modern poultry farming practices. He received an array of resources from the project, including an incubator, 50 birds for parent stock, 20 one-month-old chicks, cages for both parents and for brooding, and a poultry feed processing unit. While much of his farm's success stemmed from the support of the JSB project with technical assistance from UNDP, the continuous support of his family further propelled his entrepreneurial journey toward resounding success. As they continue to guide him, the horizon of possibilities for Dhanushka and his farm seems boundless.

